

The Cask of Amontillado

Edgar Allan Poe · 1846

First published: Godey's Lady's Book, Nov 1846

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Works_of_the_Late_Edgar_Allan_Poe_(1850)/Volume_1/The_Cask_of_Amontillado (revision 14833566), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 9–12 (accessible text, well suited to the scaffolded-support track; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about revenge and pride?
- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about deception?
- What does The Cask of Amontillado suggest about the burden of the past?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Cask of Amontillado	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*revenge and pride* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Cask of Amontillado

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Edgar Allan Poe's life or times connects to revenge and pride in “The Cask of Amontillado”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (revenge and pride, deception, the burden of the past).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown.

Historical and cultural context

The story is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city, among aristocrats with family crests and wine cellars that double as catacombs. Poe wrote it in 1846 in the middle of a bitter literary feud with the writers Thomas Dunn English and Hiram Fuller; some scholars read Montresor's revenge as Poe's fantasy of answering his critics.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in Godey's Lady's Book, one of the most popular American magazines, in November 1846.

Then: It received little critical comment at the time; Godey's readers knew Poe mainly as a critic and poet.

Now: It is a classic of revenge fiction and dramatic irony, widely taught in middle and high school, and much debated: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later, and to whom?

Overview (spoiler-free)

Montresor, insulted by Fortunato, vows revenge. During carnival he lures Fortunato, a proud wine expert, into his family's vaults with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado sherry.

Main themes

- revenge and pride: Montresor's need for revenge and Fortunato's pride in his palate both drive the plot.
- deception: almost everything Montresor says to Fortunato means something else.
- the burden of the past: the story is told half a century later; is it a boast or a confession?

Why it matters

The story is a model of dramatic irony and of a narrator who manipulates both his victim and the reader; it also raises lasting questions about revenge and justice.

Spoilers · teacher only

Montresor chains the drunken Fortunato in a niche and walls him in alive; fifty years later, he says, no one has disturbed the bones.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Cask of Amontillado: Is revenge ever justified? What would make it "fair"?
Prompt: Before we open The Cask of Amontillado: Is revenge ever justified? What would make it "fair"?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
dramatic irony; verbal irony; first-person narrator; carnival; Amontillado (a Spanish sherry); catacombs.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Edgar Allan Poe was born in Boston on 19 January 1809 to touring actors; orphaned before he was three, he was raised in Richmond, Virginia, by the merchant John Allan, with whom he later quarrelled bitterly. He attended the University of Virginia, served in the U.S. Army and was dismissed from West Point, then lived by his pen as a poet, critic and magazine editor (the Southern Literary Messenger, Graham's Magazine) in Richmond, Philadelphia and New York. He married his young cousin Virginia Clemm, who died of tuberculosis in 1847. "The Raven" (1845) made him famous but never prosperous. He is credited with inventing the modern detective story ("The Murders in the Rue Morgue," 1841) and argued that a short story should create a single "unity of effect." He died in Baltimore on 7 October 1849; the cause of his death is unknown. The world of the book. The story is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city, among aristocrats with family crests and wine cellars that double as catacombs. Poe wrote it in 1846 in the middle of a bitter literary feud with the writers Thomas Dunn English and Hiram Fuller; some scholars read Montresor's revenge as Poe's fantasy of answering his critics. Publication and reception. First published in Godey's Lady's Book, one of the most popular American magazines, in November 1846. Then: It received little critical comment at the time; Godey's readers knew Poe mainly as a critic and poet. Now: It is a classic of revenge fiction and dramatic irony, widely taught in middle and high school, and much debated: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later, and to whom?

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge" slowly and put it in my own words: Montresor says he put up with Fortunato's thousand injuries but swore revenge once Fortunato insulted him. Next, craft. I notice the exaggerated number "thousand" and the fact that he never names any injury. The strongest word is "insult": it is a smaller offense than an injury, which makes his vow of revenge seem out of proportion. Then, effect. What does the first sentence tell us about Montresor? My answer: From the first line Montresor is a narrator obsessed with pride and revenge, and he never shows us proof of the wrongs he claims.

> *The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge" slowly and put it in my own words: Montresor says he put up with Fortunato's thousand injuries but swore revenge once Fortunato insulted him. Next, craft. I notice the exaggerated number "thousand" and the fact that he never names any injury. The strongest word is "insult": it is a smaller offense than an injury, which makes his vow of revenge seem out of proportion. Then, effect. What does the first sentence tell us about Montresor? My answer: From the first line Montresor is a narrator obsessed with pride and revenge, and he never shows us proof of the wrongs he claims.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): Montresor, insulted by Fortunato, vows revenge. During carnival he lures Fortunato, a proud wine expert, into his family's vaults with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado sherry. Themes to track: revenge and pride: Montresor's need for revenge and Fortunato's pride in his palate both drive the plot. deception: almost everything Montresor says to Fortunato means something else. the burden of the past: the story is told half a century later; is it a boast or a confession?

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: revenge and pride. Prediction: Montresor's calm plan to punish Fortunato "with impunity" will be carried out through friendliness, not open anger. Question: what were the "thousand injuries," and does it matter that he never names them?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Cask of Amontillado: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: revenge and pride. Prediction: Montresor's calm plan to punish Fortunato "with impunity" will be carried out through friendliness, not open anger. Question: what were the "thousand injuries," and does it matter that he never names them?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Cask of Amontillado still matter? The story is a model of dramatic irony and of a narrator who manipulates both his victim and the reader; it also raises lasting questions about revenge and justice.
Anchor question: Why might The Cask of Amontillado still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story is a model of dramatic irony and of a narrator who manipulates both his victim and the reader; it also raises lasting questions about revenge and justice.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Poe published "The Cask of Amontillado" in Godey's Lady's Book in 1846, the year of his bitter public feud with the writer Thomas Dunn English. How might a writer caught up in rivalry and wounded pride shape a story about revenge? Answer: Accept answers such as: Poe understood how insults fester; he shows pride turning into cruelty; the story is about a grudge, and Montresor's "thousand injuries" are never named.
Exit ticket: Poe published "The Cask of Amontillado" in Godey's Lady's Book in 1846, the year of his bitter public feud with the writer Thomas Dunn English. How might a writer caught up in rivalry and wounded pride shape a story about revenge?
Answer: Accept answers such as: Poe understood how insults fester; he shows pride turning into cruelty; the story is about a grudge, and Montresor's "thousand injuries" are never named.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Cask of Amontillado.

Teacher notes · sources: Poe Museum, Richmond, "Poe's Life" (https://poemuseum.org/poes-life/); Edgar Allan Poe Society of Baltimore (texts and publication history) (https://www.eapoe.org/); Poe Society of Baltimore, "The Cask of Amontillado" (https://www.eapoe.org/works/tales/caska.htm)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The link to Poe's feud with English and Fuller is a scholarly interpretation, not a documented intention.

Lesson 2: The Cask of Amontillado

Focus: revenge carried out with perfect control

Objective: Students will analyze how irony develops in "The Cask of Amontillado" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (a man is walled up alive, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: A man is walled up alive. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("…ared. He prided himself on his connoisseurship in wine. Few Italians have the true virtuoso sp…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes a man is walled up alive.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the story fifty years later; no one has disturbed the bones.

Background: The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry.

Significance: It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and pride because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes a man is walled up alive.
Prompt: Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and pride because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)

Five key words in context, with verified word histories.

Today's words: trickle — to flow in drops; materially — to any significant degree; substantially; explicit — precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication; luckily — by good fortune; accosted — approached and spoken to. “trickle”: Origin: probably Middle English triklen, a variant of striklen (“to flow gently”); the history is not certain. “materially”: Origin: an English formation from material + -ly. “explicit”: Origin: French explicite; earlier Latin explicitus (“disentangled”). “accosted”: Origin of “accost”: Middle French accoster; earlier Old French acoster (“to stand beside”).

Words: trickle: to flow in drops · materially: to any significant degree; substantially · explicit: precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication · luckily: by good fortune · accosted: approached and spoken to

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)

Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).

The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry. It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR. Irony: Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel. Setting: The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave. Characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("Luchesi cannot tell Amontillado from Sherry") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Watch for the family crest: a foot crushing a serpent whose fangs are in the heel, with the motto "Nemo me impune lacessit" (No one attacks me with impunity): revenge as inherited identity.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" slowly and put it in my own words: Montresor says revenge only counts if he can punish Fortunato without being punished himself. Next, craft. I notice the repeated word "punish" and the legal-sounding phrase, which make revenge sound like a rule he has worked out. The strongest word is "impunity": it means freedom from consequences, so he is planning a perfect crime, not an outburst. Then, effect. What does Montresor mean by punishing "with impunity"? My answer: By punishing "with impunity," Montresor means taking revenge without being caught or punished himself; the line warns us that the friendly talk and the wine are part of a cold plan.

> *I must not only punish, but punish with impunity (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" slowly and put it in my own words: Montresor says revenge only counts if he can punish Fortunato without being punished himself. Next, craft. I notice the repeated word "punish" and the legal-sounding phrase, which make revenge sound like a rule he has worked out. The strongest word is "impunity": it means freedom from consequences, so he is planning a perfect crime, not an outburst. Then, effect. What does Montresor mean by punishing "with impunity"? My answer: By punishing "with impunity," Montresor means taking revenge without being caught or punished himself; the line warns us that the friendly talk and the wine are part of a cold plan.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The toast is ironic because Fortunato will soon be one of the buried; "long life" means the opposite. Expected link: deception and dramatic irony. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and pride? Expected: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. (Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony.)

> *I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The toast is ironic because Fortunato will soon be one of the buried; "long life" means the opposite. Expected link: deception and dramatic irony.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and pride?
Expected answer: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. (Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. When the text says “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41), it shows this directly. When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses.

Task: Annotate the story for irony, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. When the text says “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41), it shows this directly. When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge? Ask: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later? Is "My heart grew sick" guilt or the damp?

Anchor question: Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?

Facilitation: Ask: why does Montresor tell the story fifty years later? Is "My heart grew sick" guilt or the damp?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. (“I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us”, The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. (“I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us”, The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how irony shapes revenge carried out with perfect control. Key takeaway: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Irony:** Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel.
- **Setting:** The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave.
- **Characterization:** Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("Luchesi cannot tell Amontillado from Sherry") and drunkenness make him easy to lead.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and pride:** Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

Symbols and motifs

- **the family crest:** a foot crushing a serpent whose fangs are in the heel, with the motto "Nemo me impune lacessit" (No one attacks me with impunity): revenge as inherited identity.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1) His philosophy of revenge.

- “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41) Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony.
- “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83) Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand.
Evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41)
Reasoning: When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
trickle (verb)	to flow in drops	*The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.*	“trickle”: Origin: probably Middle English triklen, a variant of striklen (“to flow gently”); the history is not certain. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/trickle#Etymology)
materially (adverb)	to any significant degree; substantially	*In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.*	“materially”: Origin: an English formation from material + -ly. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/materially#Etymology)
explicit (adjective)	precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication	*I had told them that I should not return until the morning, and had given them explicit orders not to stir from the house.*	“explicit”: Origin: French explicite; earlier Latin explicitus (“disentangled”). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/explicit#Etymology)
luckily (adverb)	by good fortune	*I said to him—"My dear Fortunato, you are luckily met.*	
accosted (verb)	approached and spoken to	*He accosted me with excessive warmth, for he had been drinking much.*	“accosted”: Origin of “accost”: Middle French accoster; earlier Old French acoster (“to stand beside”). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/accost#Etymology)
impunity (noun)	exemption from punishment or loss	*I must not only punish, but punish with impunity.*	“impunity”: Origin: Middle French impunité; earlier Latin impunitas. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/impunity#Etymology)
	wear off or die down		

subsided (verb)		*When at last the clanking subsided, I resumed the trowel, and finished without interruption the fifth, the sixth, and the seventh tier.*	"subsided": Origin of "subside": Latin subsīdō ("to settle"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/subside#Etymology)
admired (verb)	feel admiration for	*You are rich, respected, admired, beloved; you are happy, as once I was.*	

Discussion questions

1. Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?
2. Where does irony appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and pride?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What reason does Montresor give for his revenge? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A thousand injuries and then an insult
2. How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado
3. What is Fortunato wearing? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells
4. What is Montresor's family motto about? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: No one attacks me with impunity
5. How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Fifty years
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Cask of Amontillado" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the story fifty years later; no one has disturbed the bones.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Cask of Amontillado"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.

8. Where and when does “The Cask of Amontillado” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.” What does “trickle” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: trickle: to flow in drops.
10. Reread: “In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.” What does “materially” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: materially: to any significant degree; substantially.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Cask of Amontillado” suggest about revenge carried out with perfect control? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.
2. Find one example of irony in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
3. How does the setting in this story shape what we understand about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. On setting: The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins “The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge.”, why might Poe have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Cask of Amontillado”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Montresor, vowing revenge for 'a thousand injuries' and an insult from Fortunato, lures the drunken wine connoisseur during carnival into his family catacombs with the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado. Deep in the vaults he chains Fortunato into a niche and walls him in alive. He tells the…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Cask of Amontillado” set up that the rest of The Cask of Amontillado will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but

punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. On characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("Luchesi cannot tell Amontillado from Sherry") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Have you ever felt someone deserved to be paid back? What is the difference between justice and revenge?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with revenge and pride? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. On characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("Luchesi cannot tell Amontillado from Sherry") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: The story (1846) is set during carnival in an unnamed Italian city. Its catacombs echo Roman and Parisian ossuaries. Amontillado is a Spanish sherry. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. On setting: The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “It is a model of dramatic and verbal irony, from Fortunato's name ('fortunate') to the toast 'to your long life'. It is a Common Core Appendix B exemplar for grades 11–CCR.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God,

Montresor" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. On characterization: Montresor is cold, patient and articulate; Fortunato's pride ("Luchesi cannot tell Amontillado from Sherry") and drunkenness make him easy to lead. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of "The Cask of Amontillado" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about "The Cask of Amontillado": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "For the love of God, Montresor" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to deception: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Poe need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: "I must not only punish, but punish with impunity" (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the irony in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. On irony: Dramatic irony saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers "True—true"; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Cask of Amontillado” treats revenge carried out with perfect control with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Cask of Amontillado see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve revenge and pride? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1): His philosophy of revenge. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about revenge carried out with perfect control? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “I drink," he said, "to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41): Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Edgar Allan Poe about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Useful evidence: “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83): Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Theme link: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Irony:** look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 38: "Here I _____ off the neck of a bottle which I drew from a long row of its fellows that lay upon the mould." Word bank: knocked, intermingling, understood, horizontally

   Key: knocked

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How long ago did the events take place, as Montresor tells it?

   A. One week
   B. Fifty years
   C. Ten years
   D. A century

   Key: B (Fifty years)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 75? "As I said these words I _____ myself among the pile of bones of which I have before spoken."

   A. appeared
   B. busied
   C. horizontally
   D. seconds

   Key: B (busied)

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Fortunato wearing?

   A. A soldier's uniform
   B. A priest's robe
   C. A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells
   D. A black mask and cloak

   Key: C (A jester's motley costume with a cap and bells)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 25? "Itook from their sconces two _____, and giving one to Fortunato, bowed him through several suites of rooms to the archway that led into the vaults."

   A. flambeaux
   B. busied
   C. gesticulation
   D. fearful

   Key: A (flambeaux)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “When at last the clanking _____, I resumed the trowel, and finished without interruption the fifth, the sixth, and the seventh tier.” Word bank: subsided, trickle, materially, explicit
   Key: subsided
7. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “I must not only punish, but punish with _____.” Word bank: materially, impunity, explicit, trickle
   Key: impunity
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What is Montresor's family motto about?
   A. No one attacks me with impunity
   B. Wine reveals truth
   C. Faith above all
   D. Mercy is strength

   Key: A (No one attacks me with impunity)
9. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] How does Montresor lure Fortunato into the vaults?
   A. With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado
   B. With a map to buried gold
   C. By challenging him to a duel
   D. By asking for medical help

   Key: A (With the promise of a rare cask of Amontillado)
10. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41: “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the _____ that repose around us”
    Key: buried
11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 75 reveal about the character or situation? “Throwing them aside, I soon uncovered a quantity of building stone and mortar.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 75) shows the situation turning on revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The words “uncovered” and “building” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.
12. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83) Answer in two or three sentences, quoting one word or phrase.
    Sample answer: Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. The evidence is “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83). This develops revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.
13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 2 reveal about the character or situation? “I continued, as was my wont, to smile in his face, and he did not perceive that my smile now was at the thought of his immolation.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 2) shows the situation turning on revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The words “immolation” and “continued” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 78 shapes its tone: “But now there came from out the niche a low laugh that erected the hairs upon my head.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “erected” (paragraph 78) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Claim: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41).
    Sample answer: When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses. The evidence is “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41) — Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. This develops revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Synthesis: trace how revenge and pride develops from the opening of “The Cask of Amontillado” to its ending. Use one quotation from each part.
    Sample answer: Near the start, “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1), which shows his philosophy of revenge. Later, “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83) — Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time.

17. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] What reason does Montresor give for his revenge?
    A. A lost duel
    B. A thousand injuries and then an insult
    C. A broken engagement
    D. A stolen inheritance

    Key: B (A thousand injuries and then an insult)

18. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 69: “It was in vain that Fortunato, uplifting his dull torch, _____ to pry into the depth of the recess.” Word bank: endeavored, understood, horizontally, seconds
    Key: endeavored

19. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “He _____ me with excessive warmth, for he had been drinking much.” Word bank: trickle, accosted, explicit, materially
    Key: accosted

20. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Complete the quotation from The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1: “I must not only punish, but punish with _____”
    Key: impunity

21. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] What does this passage most clearly show? “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41) Answer in two or three sentences, quoting one word or phrase.
    Sample answer: Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. The evidence is “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41).

22. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 25 shapes its tone: “I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “requesting” and “staircase” (paragraph 25) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

23. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 89 shapes its tone: “I thrust a torch through the remaining aperture and let it fall within.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “remaining” and “aperture” (paragraph 89) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 71 to the story's treatment of revenge and pride: “From one of these depended a short chain, from the other a padlock.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 71) develops revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words “depended” and “padlock” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “In an instant he had reached the extremity of the niche, and finding his progress arrested by the rock, stood stupidly…” (paragraph 71), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating revenge and pride as central.

25. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 2: “It must be _____, that neither by word nor deed had I given Fortunato cause to doubt my good will.” Word bank: catacombs, flambeaux, understood, seconds
    Key: understood

26. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “You are rich, respected, _____, beloved; you are happy, as once I was.” Word bank: explicit, admired, materially, trickle
    Key: admired

27. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 68 to the story's treatment of revenge and pride: “From the fourth side the bones had been thrown down, and lay promiscuously upon the earth, forming at one point a mound of some size.” Use one other moment from the story as well.
    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 68) develops revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words “promiscuously” and “forming” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “It seemed to have been constructed for no especial use within itself, but formed merely the interval between two of the…” (paragraph 68), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating revenge and pride as central.

28. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.11-12.3] What can you infer from this line? “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. The evidence is “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41).

29. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 47 shapes its tone: “A huge human foot d'or, in a field azure; the foot crushes a serpent rampant whose fangs are imbedded in the heel.” Pick two words and explain their effect.
    Sample answer: The words “imbedded” and “serpent” (paragraph 47) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

30. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.11-12.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 68? “At the most remote end of the crypt there _____ another less spacious.”

    A. farther

    B. gesticulation

    C. knocked

    D. appeared

    Key: D (appeared)

31. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.4] Analyze the word choice in “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Fortunato's last plea; Montresor echoes it mockingly. The evidence is “For the love of God, Montresor” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 83). This develops revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The words “love” and “the” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect.

32. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: The claim is persuasive in part. “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41) supports it: When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses. But “I must not only punish, but punish with impunity” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 1) complicates it: the line (his philosophy of revenge) shows the same issue from another side, and its “not” marks a limit or reversal the claim passes over. Weighing the two passages, the claim survives, but only once it admits the tension the second passage creates.

33. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.11-12.6] Which literary element does this describe in “The Cask of Amontillado”? Dramatic this device saturates the dialogue: Fortunato says he will not die of a cough, and Montresor answers ‘True—true’; Fortunato makes the Masonic sign and Montresor shows a trowel.

    A. Allusion

    B. Structure

    C. Irony

    D. Imagery

    Key: C (Irony)

34. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] In the line “The drops of moisture trickle among the bones.”, what does “trickle” most nearly mean?

    A. by good fortune

    B. to flow in drops

    C. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication

D. to any significant degree; substantially

Key: B (to flow in drops)

35. [mc · analysis · DOK 3 · Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5] Which literary element does this describe in "The Cask of Amontillado"? The descent from carnival into damp catacombs lined with bones moves from life to death; the nitre on the walls is both a pretext and an image of the grave.

A. Hyperbole

B. Allusion

C. Diction / vocabulary

D. Setting

Key: D (Setting)

36. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] In the line "I had told them that I should not return until the morning, and had given them explicit orders not to stir from the house.", what does "explicit" most nearly mean?

A. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication

B. to flow in drops

C. to any significant degree; substantially

D. by good fortune

Key: A (precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication)

37. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C2-LIT-1] In the line "In this respect I did not differ from him materially: I was skilful in the Italian vintages myself, and bought largely whenever I could.", what does "materially" most nearly mean?

A. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication

B. to any significant degree; substantially

C. by good fortune

D. to flow in drops

Key: B (to any significant degree; substantially)

38. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] In the line "I said to him—'My dear Fortunato, you are luckily met.", what does "luckily" most nearly mean?

A. to flow in drops

B. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication

C. to any significant degree; substantially

D. by good fortune

Key: D (by good fortune)

39. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Cask of Amontillado"?

A. The hunter becoming the hunted

B. Revenge carried out with perfect control

C. Science that poisons love

D. Racial pride destroying love

Key: B (Revenge carried out with perfect control)

40. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Program outcome: LeL-C3-LIT-1] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Fortunato's toast; the reply "And I to your long life" is pure irony. The evidence is “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41). This develops revenge and pride: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The words “repose” and “around” carry that meaning: they are the charged choices in the line, and changing either would soften the effect. When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 10, inference 3, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	5, 17, 2, 18, 19, 6, 8, 20, 10, 11, 21, 13, 22, 23, 14, 24	recall 9, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	3, 1, 8, 2, 25, 10, 9, 26, 12, 13, 11, 22, 14, 23, 24, 27	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	17, 2, 9, 8, 1, 25, 28, 12, 13, 11, 22, 29, 14, 23, 24, 16	recall 6, inference 4, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 17, 25, 7, 30, 4, 21, 13, 11, 14, 22, 29, 31, 16, 32, 24	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	1, 30, 3, 17, 10, 12, 13, 14, 23, 29, 33, 15, 22, 27, 24, 32	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 3
College Freshman	34, 17, 2, 19, 26, 13, 21, 23, 29, 22, 35, 31, 14, 24, 27, 32	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 6, synthesis 3
College Sophomore	36, 10, 19, 5, 37, 12, 21, 13, 14, 29, 33, 23, 22, 32, 24, 27	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 5, synthesis 3
College Junior	38, 10, 19, 36, 30, 39, 11, 23, 14, 29, 22, 31, 32, 40, 27, 24	recall 5, inference 2, analysis 5, synthesis 4
College Senior	8, 19, 17, 4, 26, 2, 31, 22, 29, 15, 14, 23, 24, 16, 32, 27	recall 6, inference 0, analysis 6, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	10, 19, 9, 34, 17, 38, 12, 29, 23, 14, 22, 32, 16, 27, 24, 40	recall 6, inference 1, analysis 4, synthesis 5

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Cask of Amontillado,” how does Poe show revenge carried out with perfect control? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the irony you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): In The Cask of Amontillado, how does Poe develop the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the irony in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Cask of Amontillado develops the idea of revenge carried out with perfect control. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of irony and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (where it begins, turns and ends) and its irony shape the reader's understanding of revenge carried out with perfect control. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Cask of Amontillado suggests about revenge carried out with perfect control. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's irony and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Edgar Allan Poe uses irony in The Cask of Amontillado to complicate the reader's understanding of revenge carried out with perfect control. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Cask of Amontillado within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Cask of Amontillado alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of revenge carried out with perfect control follows or bends those conventions, using the irony as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Cask of Amontillado and its treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's irony and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Cask of Amontillado as evidence for a larger claim about revenge carried out with perfect control in The Cask of Amontillado. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Cask of Amontillado as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of revenge carried out with perfect control. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Cask of Amontillado.

SAT-style questions

1. *I had told them that I should not return until the morning, and had given them explicit orders not to stir from the house.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “explicit” most nearly mean?

   A. exemption from punishment or loss

   B. precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication

   C. feel admiration for

   D. wear off or die down

2. *The thousand injuries of Fortunato I had borne as I best could; but when he ventured upon insult, I vowed revenge. You, who so well know the nature of my soul, will not suppose, however, that I gave utterance to a threat. At length I would be avenged; this was a point definitively settled—but the very definitiveness with which it was resolved, precluded the idea of risk. I must not only punish, but punish with impunity. A wrong is unredressed when retribution overtakes its redresser. It is equally unredressed when the avenger fails to make himself felt as such to him who has done the wrong.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Cask of Amontillado”?

   A. The loss of faith in human goodness

   B. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

   C. A crime that backfires

   D. Revenge carried out with perfect control

SAT key: 1. B (precisely and clearly expressed or readily observable; leaving nothing to implication); 2. D (Revenge carried out with perfect control)

Unit test

The Cask of Amontillado: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 71? “In its surface were two iron staples, distant from each other about two feet, _____.”

   A. busied

   B. ornamented

   C. endeavored

   D. horizontally

   Key: D (horizontally)

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 68: “Three sides of this interior crypt were still _____ in this manner.” Word bank: displacing, endeavored, fearful, ornamented

   Key: ornamented

3. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 54: “He laughed and threw the bottle upwards with a _____ I did not understand.” Word bank: displacing, flambeaux, intermingling, gesticulation

   Key: gesticulation

4. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 7? “You were not to be found, and I was _____ of losing a bargain.’”

   A. busied

   B. displacing

   C. fearful

   D. appeared

   Key: C (fearful)

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 51? “We had passed through walls of piled bones, with casks and puncheons _____, into the inmost recesses of the catacombs.”

   A. engagement

   B. understood

   C. intermingling

D. seconds

Key: C (intermingling)

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 71: “Throwing the links about his waist, it was but the work of a few _____ to secure it.” Word bank: horizontally, seconds, flambeaux, understood

   Key: seconds

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 28? “It is _____ on,’ said I; ‘but observe the white web-work which gleams from these cavern walls.”

   A. farther

   B. understood

   C. appeared

   D. seconds

   Key: A (farther)

8. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 25: “We came at length to the foot of the descent, and stood together on the damp ground of the _____ of the Montresors.” Word bank: gesticulation, catacombs, understood, knocked

   Key: catacombs

9. [fill · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Complete the quotation from paragraph 21: “It is not the _____, but the severe cold with which I perceive you are afflicted.” Word bank: displacing, catacombs, knocked, engagement

   Key: engagement

10. [mc · recall · DOK 1 · Common Core: L.9-10.4] Which word completes this sentence from paragraph 68? “Within the wall thus exposed by the _____ of the bones, we perceived a still interior recess, in depth about four feet, in width three, in height six or seven.”

    A. displacing

    B. busied

    C. appeared

    D. flambeaux

    Key: A (displacing)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 68 reveal about the character or situation? “It seemed to have been constructed for no especial use within itself, but formed merely the interval between two of the colossal supports of the roof of the catacombs, and was backed by one of their circumscribing walls of solid granite.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 68) shows the situation turning on deception: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The words “circumscribing” and “constructed” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

12. [mc · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.1] Which of these passages comes earliest in the story?

    A. “It must be understood, that neither by word nor deed had I given Fortunato cause to doubt my good will.”

    B. “You were not to be found, and I was fearful of losing a bargain.’”

C. “I continued, as was my wont, to smile in his face, and he did not perceive that my smile now was at the thought of his immolation.”

D. “And yet some fools will have it that his taste is a match for your own.”

Key: A (“It must be understood, that neither by word nor deed had I given Fortunato cause to doubt my good will.”)

13. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 29 reveal about the character or situation? “He turned towards me, and looked into my eyes with two filmy orbs that distilled the rheum of intoxication.” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 29) shows the situation turning on the burden of the past: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The words “intoxication” and “distilled” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

14. [short · inference · DOK 2 · Common Core: RL.9-10.3] What does this passage from paragraph 79 reveal about the character or situation? “We will have many a rich laugh about it at the palazzo—he! he! he!—over our wine—he! he! he!’” Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

Sample answer: The passage (paragraph 79) shows the situation turning on the burden of the past: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The words “palazzo” are the proof, because they show how the moment looks to the people in it. They suggest more than the narrator states outright.

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 68 shapes its tone: “Its walls had been lined with human remains, piled to the vault overhead, in the fashion of the great catacombs of Paris.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “catacombs” and “overhead” (paragraph 68) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to the burden of the past: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

16. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 71 shapes its tone: “In an instant he had reached the extremity of the niche, and finding his progress arrested by the rock, stood stupidly bewildered.” Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words “bewildered” and “extremity” (paragraph 71) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to deception: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 78 to the story's treatment of deception: “I had finished a portion of the last and the eleventh; there remained but a single stone to be fitted and plastered in.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 78) develops deception: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words “plastered” and “eleventh” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “We will have many a rich laugh about it at the palazzo—he! he! he!—over our wine—he! he! he!’” (paragraph 79), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating deception as central.

18. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 67 shapes its tone: “We passed through a range of low arches, descended, passed on, and descending again, arrived at a deep crypt, in which the foulness of the air caused our flambeaux rather to

glow than flame." Pick two words and explain their effect.

Sample answer: The words "descending" and "descended" (paragraph 67) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to the burden of the past: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

19. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 77 shapes its tone: "Asuccession of loud and shrill screams, bursting suddenly from the throat of the chained form, seemed to thrust me violently back." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words "violently" and "bursting" (paragraph 77) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to deception: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

20. [short · analysis · DOK 3 · Common Core: RL.9-10.4] Analyze how the word choice in this passage from paragraph 15 shapes its tone: "And yet some fools will have it that his taste is a match for your own." Pick two words and explain their effect.

    Sample answer: The words its wording (paragraph 15) make the tone heavy and deliberate rather than neutral. That weight points the reader to deception: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. The author chooses them so the moment feels significant instead of passing.

21. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.9-10.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 23 to the story's treatment of the burden of the past: "Putting on a mask of black silk, and drawing a roquelaire closely about my person, I suffered him to hurry me to my palazzo." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 23) develops the burden of the past: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words "roquelaire" and "suffered" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "I passed down a long and winding staircase, requesting him to be cautious as he followed." (paragraph 25), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating the burden of the past as central.

22. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 77 to the story's treatment of the burden of the past: "I placed my hand upon the solid fabric of the catacombs, and felt satisfied." Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 77) develops the burden of the past: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words "catacombs" and "satisfied" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "But now there came from out the niche a low laugh that erected the hairs upon my head." (paragraph 78), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating the burden of the past as central.

23. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 72 to the story's treatment of the burden of the past: "But I must first render you all the little attentions in my power.'" Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 72) develops the burden of the past: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words "attentions" and "little" carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in "Throwing them aside, I soon uncovered a quantity of building stone and mortar." (paragraph 75), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating the burden of the past as central.

24. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 26 to the story's treatment of deception: “The gait of my friend was unsteady, and the bells upon his cap jingled as he strode.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 26) develops deception: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words “unsteady” and “jingled” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “He turned towards me, and looked into my eyes with two filmy orbs that distilled the rheum of intoxication.” (paragraph 29), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating deception as central.

25. [short · synthesis · DOK 4 · Common Core: RL.11-12.2] Connect this passage from paragraph 51 to the story's treatment of deception: “I paused again, and this time I made bold to seize Fortunato by an arm above the elbow.” Use one other moment from the story as well.

    Sample answer: This passage (paragraph 51) develops deception: Montresor's rules for revenge ("I must not only punish but punish with impunity") show a man who has thought this through for a long time. Its words “paused” carry that idea into this moment. The same concern returns in “We passed through a range of low arches, descended, passed on, and descending again, arrived at a deep crypt, in which…” (paragraph 67), so the two passages read as a pattern, not a single moment. Together they show the story treating deception as central.

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 12, 14, 15, 16, 17	recall 10, inference 5, analysis 2, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	8, 6, 3, 9, 5, 10, 1, 4, 7, 2, 14, 12, 12, 11, 16, 15, 18, 17	recall 10, inference 4, analysis 3, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	8, 9, 3, 5, 6, 7, 1, 2, 12, 12, 11, 14, 13, 19, 15, 20, 17, 21	recall 8, inference 5, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	4, 6, 7, 9, 3, 8, 10, 14, 13, 11, 12, 12, 16, 18, 19, 15, 22, 17	recall 7, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	10, 6, 9, 4, 8, 2, 12, 13, 14, 12, 11, 19, 20, 16, 18, 23, 17, 22	recall 6, inference 5, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	4, 3, 2, 12, 11, 13, 14, 18, 20, 15, 19, 16, 21, 24, 23, 17, 22, 25	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Freshman	3, 9, 5, 11, 12, 12, 14, 16, 18, 20, 15, 19, 23, 24, 17, 21, 25, 22	recall 3, inference 4, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Sophomore	3, 8, 12, 11, 12, 14, 13, 19, 15, 18, 20, 16, 25, 22, 23, 17, 21, 24	recall 2, inference 5, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Junior	7, 9, 11, 12, 12, 13, 14, 19, 18, 20, 16, 15, 24, 25, 22, 21, 23, 17	recall 2, inference 5, analysis 5, synthesis 6
College Senior	8, 5, 11, 13, 12, 14, 12, 15, 19, 18, 20, 16, 25, 17, 21, 23, 24, 22	recall 2, inference 5, analysis 5, synthesis 6
Graduate / PhD	9, 5, 13, 12, 11, 12, 14, 20, 19, 18, 15, 16, 24, 22, 23, 17, 25, 21	recall 2, inference 5, analysis 5, synthesis 6

Final paper

The Cask of Amontillado: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Edgar Allan Poe develops revenge and pride across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Cask of Amontillado and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to deception.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Cask of Amontillado. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Cask of Amontillado finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of the burden of the past. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor	Exemplary	Proficient	Developing	Beginning
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.	Specific, arguable and precise; it organizes every section.	Clear and arguable, but broad in places.	States a topic or a summary more than an argument.	Missing, or restates the prompt.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.	Accurate, well-chosen quotations from across the work, all cited; meets the requirement.	Accurate and cited, but clustered in one part of the work.	Too few quotations, or some inaccurate or uncited.	Little or no quoted evidence.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.	Explains how specific words, structure and devices create meaning; weighs a competing reading.	Explains the evidence, with some close reading.	Mostly summary; the link to the claim is asserted, not shown.	Summary only.
Organization	15					

		Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.	Each paragraph advances the argument; transitions show logic.	Logical order with minor jumps.	Order is loose; paragraphs repeat or drift.	No discernible structure.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.	Formal, precise, present tense; MLA format; virtually error-free.	Formal with a few errors that do not obscure meaning.	Informal or error-prone in ways that distract.	Errors obscure meaning.

Exemplar paragraph: Montresor's revenge depends on irony: he tells Fortunato the truth in words that Fortunato cannot understand. The text makes this visible when it says “I drink,’ he said, ‘to the buried that repose around us” (The Cask of Amontillado, paragraph 41). When Fortunato toasts "the buried that repose around us," Montresor replies "And I to your long life," knowing he is about to bury him; the reader hears the double meaning Fortunato misses. A full paper would carry this reading through the beginning, middle and end, and answer the strongest competing reading.

Essay assignments

Essay: Revenge and pride

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about revenge and pride. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops revenge and pride across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of revenge and pride. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of revenge and pride, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of revenge and pride in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on revenge and pride in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Deception

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about deception. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops deception across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of deception. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of deception in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of deception, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of deception in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on deception in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on deception in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: The burden of the past

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Cask of Amontillado teaches about the burden of the past. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Edgar Allan Poe develops the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Edgar Allan Poe develops the burden of the past across The Cask of Amontillado. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Cask of Amontillado (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of the burden of the past. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Edgar Allan Poe's choices in The Cask of Amontillado (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of the burden of the past, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Cask of Amontillado's treatment of the burden of the past in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on the burden of the past in The Cask of Amontillado, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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